

TABLE 3.2 : POPULATION IN THE WET ZONE AND THE DRY ZONE

Census Year	Population in 1000		Percentage		Density	
	Wet Zone	Dry Zone	Wet Zone	Dry Zone	Wet Zone	Dry Zone
1871	1813.4	586.9	75.6	24.4	190	38
1881	2023.4	646.2	75.8	24.2	212	42
1891	2285.5	722.2	75.9	24.1	240	47
1901	2763.2	802.7	77.5	22.5	290	52
1911	3228.9	877.4	78.6	21.4	339	57
1921	3576.1	921.7	79.5	20.5	375	60
1931	4324.1	982.7	80.0	20.0	454	64
1946	5426.6	1230.7	81.5	18.5	570	80
1953	6523.1	1574.7	79.6	20.4	685	102
1963	8191.4	2390.6	77.4	22.6	860	155
1971	9633.6	3056.3	75.9	24.1	1009	198

The decline in the proportion of the population in the Dry Zone until 1946, was due to the prevalence of Malaria which not only accounted for the death rates, but also discouraged the movement of people into the Dry Zone districts. On the other hand it is also likely that some migration from the Dry Zone to the more salubrious Wet Zone would have taken place. The eradication of Malaria after 1946, the restoration of ancient irrigation works and the setting up of colonization schemes in the Dry Zone resulted in the migration from the heavily populated Wet Zone to the Dry Zone in search of land and other prospects. Hence, after 1946 the proportion of the population in the Dry Zone began to rise gradually, and correspondingly there has been a decline in the proportion of the population of the Wet Zone. Throughout the period 1871-1971 the crude density in the Wet Zone was more than five times that of the Dry Zone. In 1871 the density of population in the Wet Zone was 190 per square mile while in the Dry Zone it was 38. In 1971 it was 1009 in the Wet Zone and 198 in the Dry Zone. During this hundred year period, density of the Wet Zone increased by about 820 persons per square mile while the corresponding increase in the Dry Zone was only 160 persons per square mile.

3.3 Crude density of population in Sri Lanka 1971

The population density of Sri Lanka in 1971 was 508 persons per square mile which is more than 5 times that of 1871 (95 persons per square mile). During the latter part of the 19th century the rate of increase was less than 2 persons per square mile per year, and in the first half of the 20th century it was nearly four persons per square mile per year. Each year 8 to 15 persons were added to a square mile during the latter half of the 20th century (see Table 3.3).

TABLE 3.3 : INCREASE IN DENSITY FROM 1871 to 1971 in SRI LANKA

Census Year	Density (persons per square mile)	Intercensal increase in persons per sq. mile	Average annual increase in density
1871	95	-	-
1881	109	14	1.4
1891	119	10	1.0
1901	141	22	2.2
1911	162	21	2.1
1921	178	16	1.6
1931	210	32	3.2
1946	263	53	3.5
1953	320	57	8.1
1963	423	103	10.3
1971	508	125	15.2